Ruin Spreads: Cain, the Flood, and Babel

Genesis 4–11

> **The big idea:** Sin does not stay small. One bite of fruit grows into murder, a world filled with violence, and a tower built for human glory. But every judgment carries mercy, and grace always comes first: Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.

Before you meet: Read

Genesis 4:1–16 | Genesis 6:5–22 | Genesis 8:20–9:17 | Genesis 11:1–9 | Hebrews 12:24

Open (5 minutes)

Think of a small problem you ignored that grew into a big one: a leak, a debt, a grudge. What happened?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

God warned Cain, "If you do not do well, sin is _____ at the door. Its desire is for you, and you must _____ over it." *(Genesis 4:7)*

Lamech boasted, "If Cain's revenge is sevenfold, then Lamech's is _____." *(Genesis 4:24)*

"But Noah found _____ in the eyes of the LORD." *(Genesis 6:8)*

When everyone was inside the ark, "the LORD _____ him in." *(Genesis 7:16)*

"I have set my _____ in the cloud, and it shall be a sign of the _____ between me and the earth." *(Genesis 9:13)*

At Babel they said, "Come, let us build ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the heavens, and let us make a _____ for ourselves." *(Genesis 11:4)*

Discuss

1. God told Cain that sin was "crouching at the door." What does it look like to "rule over it"? What help do Christians have that Cain did not? *Genesis 4:6–7*

2. Lamech multiplied revenge. Jesus multiplied forgiveness. Why is keeping score so natural to us? What would it take for you to stop? *Genesis 4:24; Matthew 18:21–22*

3. “Noah found favor” comes before “Noah was a righteous man.” Why does that order matter? *Genesis 6:8–9*

4. The flood washed the earth but not the human heart. What does that tell us about what we really need? *Genesis 8:21*

5. At Babel, people tried to make a name for themselves. Where do you see that same drive today, in our culture or in yourself? *Genesis 11:4–9*

6. Abel’s blood cried out for justice. Jesus’ blood “speaks a better word than the blood of Abel.” What better word do you need to hear from him this week? *Hebrews 12:24*

Apply this week

Put down the ledger. Think of one person you are keeping score against, and pray for them by name every day this week. Then name the sin crouching at your own door, confess it to God, and ask for his help to rule over it.

Memory verse

“But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.”

Genesis 6:8

Pray

Thank God that his mercy spreads wherever sin does, and that grace comes first. Ask him to help you forgive as you have been forgiven, and thank him for Jesus, the one door to safety, whose blood speaks a better word.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 5

Ruin Spreads: Cain, the Flood, and Babel

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Genesis 4:1–16 aloud. Then read Genesis 6:5–8 and 11:1–9.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 2, 3, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Trace the pattern in each story: sin, judgment, mercy. Then show the Turn: Abel and Hebrews 12:24, the ark and its one door, Babel and Pentecost (Acts 2).
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 6 (Genesis 12, 15, and 22).

Main points to land

1. Sin grows. From one bite of fruit to a murder, a song of revenge, a world filled with violence, and a tower of pride (Genesis 4:8, 23–24; 6:11; 11:4).
2. Every judgment carries mercy: a mark to protect Cain, an ark for Noah, a rainbow covenant to preserve the world, and a scattering that limited human pride.
3. Grace comes first. Noah found favor before he is called righteous, and he was saved by faith (Genesis 6:8–9; Hebrews 11:7).
4. The flood did not change the human heart (Genesis 8:21). We need more than a fresh start. We need a new heart and a Savior.
5. Jesus answers these chapters: his blood speaks a better word than Abel's, he is the one door to safety, he multiplies forgiveness where Lamech multiplied revenge, and at Pentecost he began gathering the scattered nations.

Core doctrine to teach

God's Justice and Mercy CORE DOCTRINE 5 OF 26

God is perfectly just. He does not overlook evil, and sin brings real judgment, as the flood shows. He is also rich in mercy. He saved Noah and his family, set his bow in the sky, and patiently holds back judgment so that people may turn to him. *Genesis 6:5–8; 9:8–17; Exodus 34:6–7; 2 Peter 3:9*

Answer key (Observe)

1. crouching; rule
2. seventy-sevenfold
3. favor
4. shut
5. bow; covenant

6. name

Questions people will ask

Who were the "sons of God" in Genesis 6?
Faithful Christians read this in more than one way. Augustine and Calvin saw the godly line of Seth marrying into Cain's line. Others see fallen angels (Jude 6) or powerful rulers. On any reading, the line between those who called on God and those who did not was disappearing. Do not let the group get stuck here.

Did the flood cover the whole earth?
The plain reading, which this study follows, is a global flood (Genesis 7:19). Some Christians who hold firmly to Scripture read it as vast but regional, since the whole earth sometimes means the whole known world (Genesis 41:57). Either way, it was a real judgment in real history, and Jesus treated it as a preview of the final judgment (Matthew 24:37–39).

If God regretted making man, did he make a mistake or change his mind?
No. God does not change (Malachi 3:6), and he is not a man, that he should have regret (1 Samuel 15:29). Genesis uses human language to show something true: God is not indifferent to evil. His unchanging holy love stands against what humanity had become.

Does 1 Peter 3:21 mean baptism saves us?
Peter says baptism corresponds to the ark, but he adds that it is not the removal of dirt. The risen Christ saves, received by faith, and baptism is God's sign and seal of that rescue. Grace is not so tied to baptism that no one can be saved without it, or that everyone baptized is surely born again (WCF 28.5). Point people to Christ, the one door.

Closing prayer

Father, we see ourselves in Cain's anger, Lamech's score-keeping, and Babel's pride. Thank you that your mercy has always run ahead of our sin, that grace came first for Noah, and that it comes first for us. Thank you for Jesus, whose blood speaks a better word than Abel's. Bring each of us in through the one door while it is open. Amen.